2026 SCHOOL FOOD WASTE REDUCTION CHALLENGE

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Case Study

The Golden Plate - Making Food Waste Reduction Fun, Student-Led, and Visible

Food waste prevention is one of the most effective ways to reduce greenhouse gas emissions and strengthen Canada's food system.

At St. Andrew's College in Aurora, Ontario, students partnered with food services staff to explore how everyday choices in the cafeteria could reduce avoidable food waste. Guided by a food waste prevention mindset, their student-led Golden Plate initiative demonstrates how positive incentives, visibility, and youth leadership can help schools build lasting habits that reduce waste while fostering a stronger community culture.



The Spark: Turning Plates into Positive Climate Action

Students at St. Andrew's College in the Environmental Council, known as the "Green Guys" launched an initiative focused on reducing food waste called the "Golden Plate". Central to the program was a simple idea: behaviour change works best when it is encouraging, visible, and rewarding.

Rather than focusing on what community members were doing wrong, the Green Guys designed a game-like challenge that celebrated finishing meals and being mindful of portions.

Each week, a small team of student volunteers, known as Compost Coaches, tracked clean plates during lunchtime. Students who consistently finished their meals were recorded, and winners were announced the following week at the school assembly.

Golden Plate winners earned two simple, but highly motivating rewards:

- Skipping the cafeteria line for a week
- Choosing a Friday menu item



“We’ve learned that when it comes to education and behaviour change, telling people they’re doing something wrong isn’t always very effective. So we focused on a positive

incentive model—rewarding students for what they're already doing well instead of wagging our finger. Our food services team has been AMAZING, helping strengthen the initiative by letting winners submit meal requests."
— Matthew Jaekel, Teacher and Green Guy Lead, St. Andrew's College

Real Impact

What began as a fun incentive quickly led to noticeable changes in the dining hall.

Before the Golden Plate launched, fewer than half of dining hall plates were consistently finished. That number climbed to as high as 75% clean plates, signalling a meaningful shift in habits and awareness.

Beyond the numbers, the initiative:

- Increased student awareness around food waste and portion choice
- Strengthened relationships between students and kitchen staff
- Made sustainability a visible, everyday part of school life

The Golden Plate helped students see that small, consistent actions can add up to meaningful environmental impact.



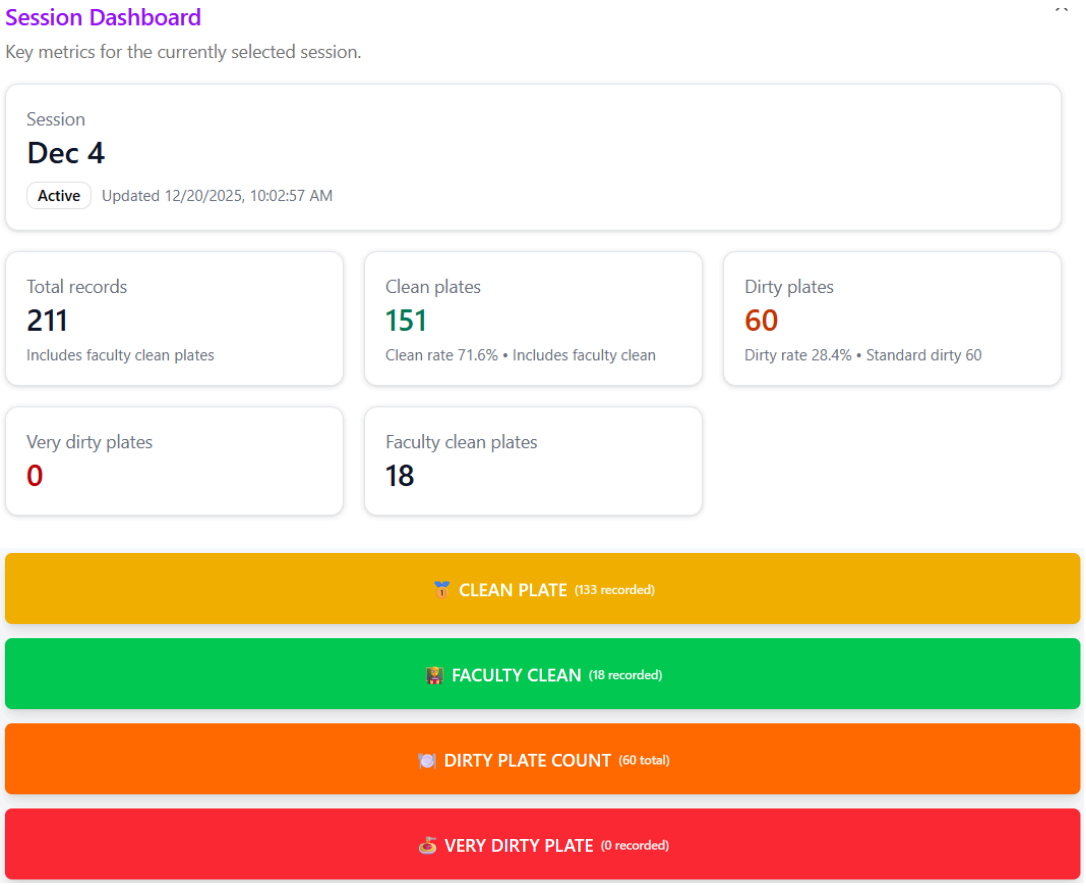
"*As a food service team, we see every day how small choices on the plate add up. The Golden Plate program has turned 'clean plates' into a point of pride, and we've watched students become more mindful about portions and waste. It's strengthened our*

connection with them, too. When students help choose menu items and see their ideas reflected in the dining hall, they take more ownership of both the food and the impact it has on the environment." — Bertrand Yeung, Head Chef at St. Andrew's College

Student Leadership & Recognition Building Momentum

A defining feature of the Golden Plate's success was student ownership. With one teacher acting as a mentor, students led nearly every aspect of the initiative, including:

- Monitoring and tallying clean plates every week
- Sharing progress and education through assemblies and school communications
- Social media and storytelling moments that reinforced school pride
- Developing a website tracking app and expanding the initiative



The initiative also sparked innovation. Students designed a student-built website to help track clean plates and visualize progress — a tool now being explored for use by other

schools. It's customizable and continues to improve as users provide helpful feedback. These reinforcements helped transform food waste reduction into a shared goal rather than an obligation.



"*The reason Nick and I are building the website is rooted in environmentalism, but it also extends beyond that. We're showing our peers that we students can be catalysts for change. We don't have to wait for "professionals" or use what's already there. By understanding our communities, we can propose initiatives and act on them to tackle the issues we care about most."* — Jiajun Li, Grade 12 Green Guy and Co-Website Developer



Growing the Movement: Middle School Students Join In

The momentum created by the Green Guys has begun to ripple through the St. Andrew's community. Their leadership inspired the Middle School's Green Team, who eagerly partnered with the senior students to learn the ropes of becoming Compost Coaches and to bring the Golden Plate program to their own lunch periods.

Middle School students explored how to use the tracking website, identified clean plates, and learned how positive recognition can spark real behaviour change. The response was immediate: students were excited to take part, proud to be noticed for making sustainable choices, and motivated by simple rewards, such as moving to the front of the lunch line and having a say in the menu.

By extending the program to younger grades, St. Andrew's is building a culture where food waste reduction becomes a shared, school-wide habit. The Middle School rollout shows that when students are empowered, supported, and celebrated, they rise to the challenge and help strengthen the impact for the whole community.

"What makes this program powerful isn't just cleaner plates, it's about building a culture where sustainability feels normal and shared. When students lead, sustainability stops feeling like rules to follow and starts becoming a part of who we are as a community."

— Kelsey Collins, Green Team Lead

Want to Build Your Own Golden Plate Program?

One of the most powerful insights from the Golden Plate is its adaptability. Schools do not need specialized equipment, major funding, or complex systems to run a similar program.

Elementary schools might:

- Award the Golden Plate in individual classes rather than individuals
- Use the program as a positive teaching moment about food waste and healthy eating
- Share progress through announcements or assemblies

High schools might:

- Create a school-specific award
- Establish student Compost Coaches
- Offer small individual and large group meaningful incentives

Universal steps for any school include:

- Choosing a fun, school-specific award
- Keeping tracking simple (paper tally, chart, or app)
- Empowering student leaders
- Celebrating progress consistently
- Posting and presenting results regularly

Learn More

- Watch the Golden Plate intro video: https://youtu.be/vQN0X-7xXVo
- Read the Green Schools Alliance feature: https://www.greenschoolsalliance.org/best-practices-1/golden-plate
- Explore the student-developed Golden Plate website: https://goldenplate.ca/